How to Tell Wild Animals

The big idea

How to Tell Wild Animals by **Carolyn Wells** is a **humorous** poem that pretends to teach us how to identify wild animals — but every method involves meeting the animal at very close, dangerous range. The fun lies in its **wordplay** and absurd situations.

Animals and how to "tell" them

Animal	How to recognise it (humorously)
Asian Lion	a large, tawny beast that **roars at you as you are dying**
Bengal Tiger	a noble wild beast with **black stripes on a yellow ground** that "greets" you while you roam — just notice if he eats you
Leopard	a beast whose hide is **peppered with spots**; you will know it as soon as it has **leapt on you**
Bear	a creature in your yard who **hugs you very, very hard**
Hyena	it comes with a **merry smile**
Crocodile	told apart from the hyena because it **weeps** (sheds false tears)
Chameleon	a creature with **no ears and no wings** that sits on a tree; if you **see nothing** on the tree, it is the chameleon (it changes colour)

WHERE THE HUMOUR COMES FROM

To "tell" an animal you must already be attacked by it — which means it is too late! The playful tone makes deadly danger funny.

Poetic devices

- **Rhyme scheme: ababcc** in each six-line stanza.
- **Poetic licence:** the poet bends spelling and grammar for rhyme and rhythm — "**dyin'**" to rhyme with "**Lion**", and "**lept**" instead of "leapt".
- **Pun / wordplay:** "**tell**" = identify (and also "tell apart"); the deadly "**hug**" of the bear; the hyena's "merry smile".
- **Idiom:** "**crocodile tears**" (false sorrow).
- **Imagery** and **humour** throughout; **enjambment**.

NOT A SCIENCE LESSON

The poem is not a real guide to identifying animals. Write that it is **humorous** and full of **wordplay**.

Theme and value points

- Humour can make even frightening subjects enjoyable.
- Language is playful — puns and idioms can carry double meanings.
- Wild animals are dangerous; respect them from a distance.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

How can you identify the Asian Lion / Bengal Tiger / Leopard? What does "crocodile tears" mean? Find examples of poetic licence. Why is the poem humorous? What is the rhyme scheme?

Quick recap

- Carolyn Wells; humorous poem; ababcc.
- Lion roars, tiger greets, leopard pounces, bear hugs, hyena smiles, crocodile weeps, chameleon invisible.

- Devices: poetic licence (dyin'/Lion), pun, idiom, humour.

Practice questions

1. How can you recognise the Bengal Tiger, according to the poem?
   (a) A noble wild beast with black stripes on a yellow ground (b) It weeps over its victim (c) It hugs you (d) It has no ears
2. "Crocodile tears" means
   (a) tears of joy (b) false sorrow (c) deep grief (d) tears in the river
3. How will you know the hyena?
   (a) By its spots (b) By its roar (c) By its merry smile (d) By its tears
4. "Dyin'" to rhyme with "Lion" is an example of
   (a) simile (b) metaphor (c) poetic licence (d) personification
5. The rhyme scheme of each stanza is
   (a) abab (b) aabb (c) ababcc (d) abcabc
6. How can you identify the chameleon?
   (a) It roars at night (b) It hugs you (c) It has stripes (d) If you see nothing on the tree, it is the chameleon
7. Why is "How to Tell Wild Animals" a humorous poem?

Answers: 1. a 2. b 3. c 4. c 5. c 6. d 7. see notes